

PURELIVINGZONE · FREE GUIDE

The Cast Iron Guide

Bring a rusted, forgotten pan back to a smooth, naturally non-stick, lifetime tool.

You watched the 60 seconds. Here is the whole thing. A cast iron pan is almost impossible to kill. Rust is not the end — it is surface-deep, and under it is a tool that can outlive you. Here is how to bring one back, and how to keep it so it is never lost again.

STRIP THE RUST

- **Scour it down** — scrub off the rust with steel wool or a stiff brush and a little dish soap. Soap is fine at this stripping stage; it is only the seasoned, bare-iron stage you keep soap light on later. Coarse salt and a halved potato also lift light rust.
 - **Rinse and dry completely** — towel it, then set it on a low burner for a few minutes until every trace of moisture is gone. Water is the only real enemy of iron.
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SEASON IT

- **Thin oil, everywhere** — rub a very thin coat of a high-smoke-point oil (grapeseed, flaxseed, or plain vegetable oil) over the whole pan, inside and out, then wipe it back until it looks almost dry. Too much oil turns sticky and blotchy.
 - **Bake it upside down** — place it upside down in the oven at about 450–500°F for one hour, foil underneath to catch drips. The oil polymerizes into a hard, slick black layer.
 - **Repeat two or three times** — let it cool, then add more thin coats. Each layer builds the non-stick surface.
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- **Cook in it often** — searing and frying season it a little more every time you use it.
 - **Clean it gently and warm** — hot water and a brush while it is still warm; scrub stuck bits with coarse salt. Dry it at once and wipe with a single drop of oil.
 - **Never soak it or let it air-dry** — standing water brings the rust straight back. A pan left wet overnight is how these got abandoned in the first place.
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KEEP THIS IN MIND

Skip the dishwasher and the long soak forever. Ninety seconds — hot water, a brush, a quick dry on the burner, a wipe of oil — is the whole ritual. That ritual is why these pans get handed down instead of thrown out.

The pan your grandfather seasoned can feed your grandchildren. Few things you own will ever be able to say that. — The Sage

SOURCES Lodge Cast Iron, Use & Care (lodgecastiron.com) · America's Test Kitchen · University cooperative extension, home & family resources